CYBER SAFETY GUY

SNAPCHAT

THE BASICS PARENTS NEED TO KNOW

Snapchat is a photo and video messaging app where messages (Snaps) disappear after being viewed. It's fun and creative – but it also comes with risks. Here's what parents need to know.

800M+ monthly active Snapchat users worldwide — Snap Inc. (2024)

75% of 13–34 year olds in the US use Snapchat — Pew Research (2023)

30+ minutes per day is the average time teens spend on Snapchat — DataReportal (2024)

TOP 3 app teens say they use to stay in touch with friends — Pew Research (2023)

KEY FEATURES – WHAT MAKES SNAPCHAT DIFFERENT

SNAPS — Photos or videos that disappear after being viewed (1–10 seconds by default).

STORIES — Snaps that last 24 hours and can be viewed by friends or everyone (public story).

SNAP MAP — Shows your location on a map to friends who have location sharing on.

CHAT — Messages disappear by default after being viewed in chat.

STREAKS — You and a friend send Snaps back and forth for consecutive days to keep a Streak.

SPOTLIGHT — Public feed of user-submitted Snaps. Anyone can view, like and share.

SNAP SCORE — A score that goes up when you send/receive Snaps. Many teens focus on getting higher.

WHY KIDS LOVE SNAPCHAT

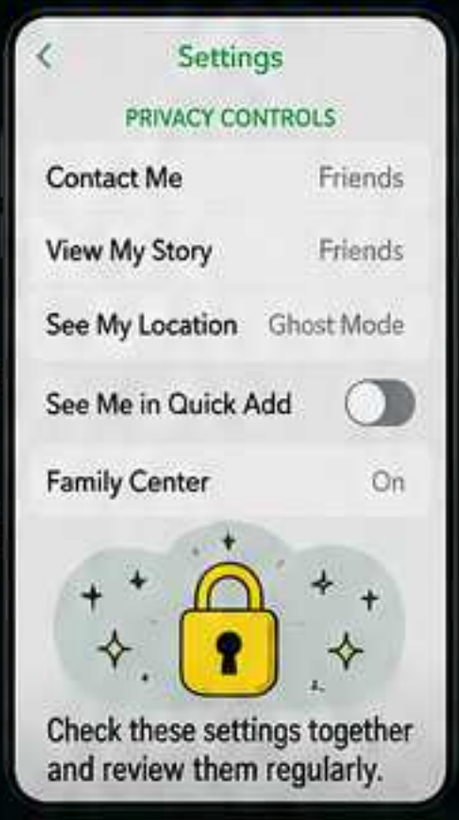
- It feels private and "in the moment"
- Fun filters, Lenses and creative tools
- Easy way to stay in touch with friends
- Streaks create connection and routine
- Stories and Spotlight help them express themselves

RISKS PARENTS SHOULD KNOW

- **Disappearing doesn't mean gone** — Screenshots, screen recordings and camera photos can save Snaps.
- **Strangers can contact your child** — Anyone can send a Chat or view a public Story/Spotlight.
- **Location sharing can expose them** — Snap Map can reveal where your child is – in real time.
- **Inappropriate content exists** — Spotlight and Stories can include sensitive or explicit content.
- **Pressure & comparison** — Streaks, Snap Score and filters can affect self-esteem.

SNAPCHAT PRIVACY: WHAT PARENTS CAN CONTROL

- **Who can contact them** — Restrict to "Friends" so only accepted friends can message.
- **View My Story** — Limit to "Friends" or "Custom" instead of "Everyone".
- **See My Location (Snap Map)** — Choose "Ghost Mode" or "My Friends (except...)" for more privacy.
- **See Me in Quick Add** — Turn off so your child isn't suggested to people they don't know.
- **Family Center** — Connect with your teen to see their privacy settings and who they've friended (not content).



Check these settings together and review them regularly.

TIPS FOR PARENTS

- **Talk early and often.** Keep the conversation open and judgment-free.
- **Know their friends.** Help them understand who's safe to talk to.
- **Review privacy settings together.** Make them part of the process.
- **Be aware of Snap Map.** Talk about location sharing and safety.
- **Discuss what's not okay.** Set clear boundaries around content and behavior.
- **Encourage them to speak up.** If something feels off, tell a trusted adult.

CONVERSATION STARTERS

- Who are you snapping or chatting with most?
- Do you know them in real life?
- How do you know if someone is trustworthy online?
- Have you ever seen something that made you uncomfortable?
- Do you feel pressure to keep a Streak or reply right away?
- What would you do if a stranger sent you something weird?

QUICK DO'S & DON'TS

DO

- Encourage open conversations
- Report and block when needed
- Use strong, unique passwords
- Keep devices in common areas
- Remind them: respectful & kind

DON'T

- Don't take away their device if they open up – listen first
- Don't ignore red flags
- Don't overshare their location or personal info
- Don't assume "disappearing" means "safe"

NEED TO TALK? CHILDLINE | **0800 1111** childline.org.uk | **YOU ARE NOT ALONE** We're here for you.